Cartesian Path

1. Content Description

This course introduces how to implement Cartesian path planning of the robot arm in MoveIt2.

Conventional joint-space trajectory planning usually only guarantees the poses of the start and end points, and the trajectory of the robot arm's end effector during motion is typically a curve or an arc; however, in industrial tasks such as welding, cutting, glue application, and straight-line pick-and-place, the end effector is often required to strictly move along a 3D straight-line trajectory.

MoveIt provides a Cartesian path planning service that allows us to specify a series of spatial waypoints. The algorithm automatically performs continuous inverse-solution interpolation along the end-effector straight line in tiny steps, generating a smooth linear motion trajectory.

---

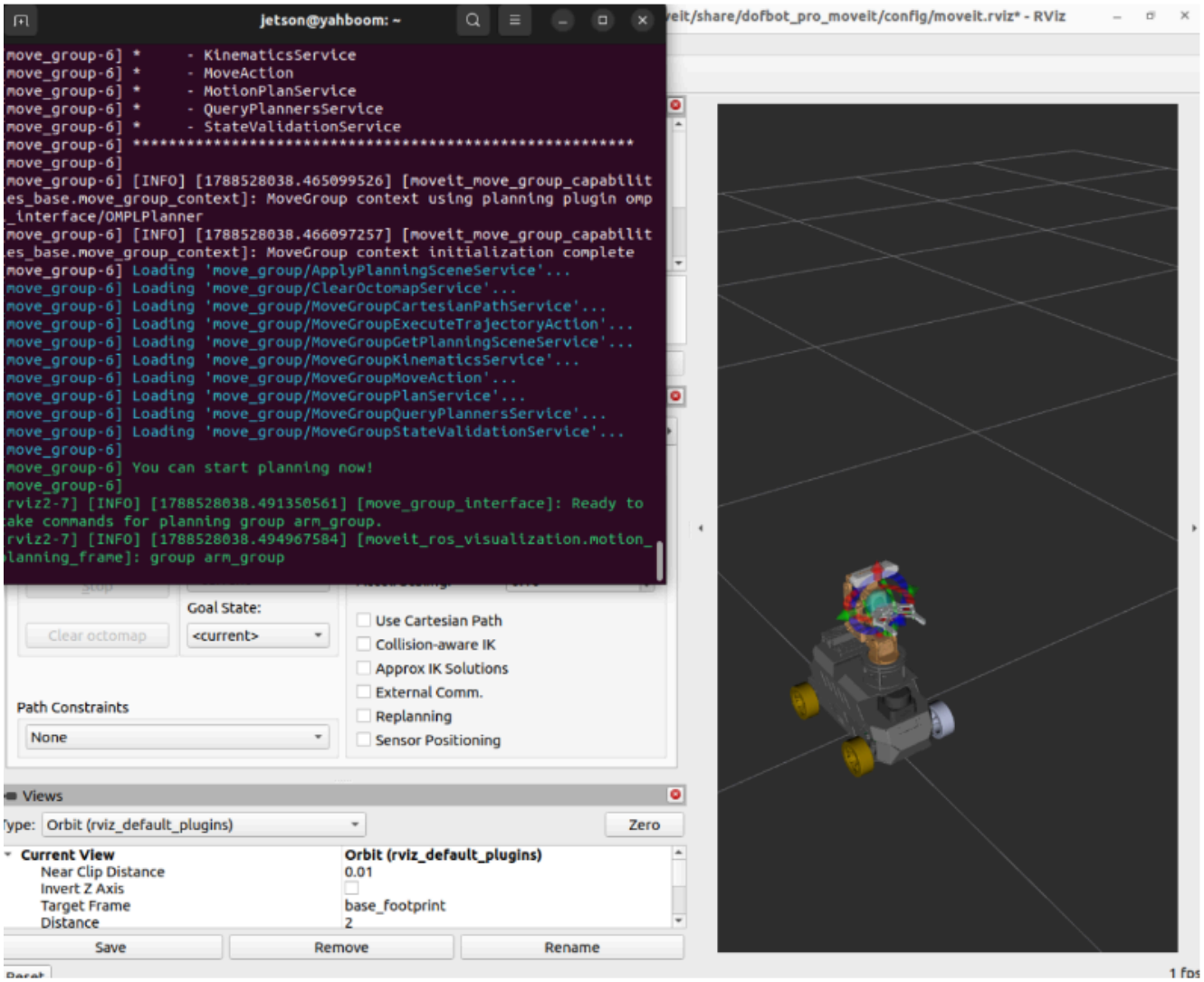
2. Launch and Operation Steps

2.1 Launching the MoveIt2 Simulation Environment

Enter the following command in the terminal to launch the MoveIt2 simulation environment:

```
ros2 launch dofbot_pro_moveit demo_3d.launch.py
```

Once the program starts, when **You can start planning now!** is output in the terminal, it means the MoveIt2 planning node is ready, as shown in the figure below:



2.2 Starting Real-Machine Linkage (Optional)

If you want the simulated robot arm motion to synchronously control the real physical robot arm, open another terminal and run the driver conversion node:

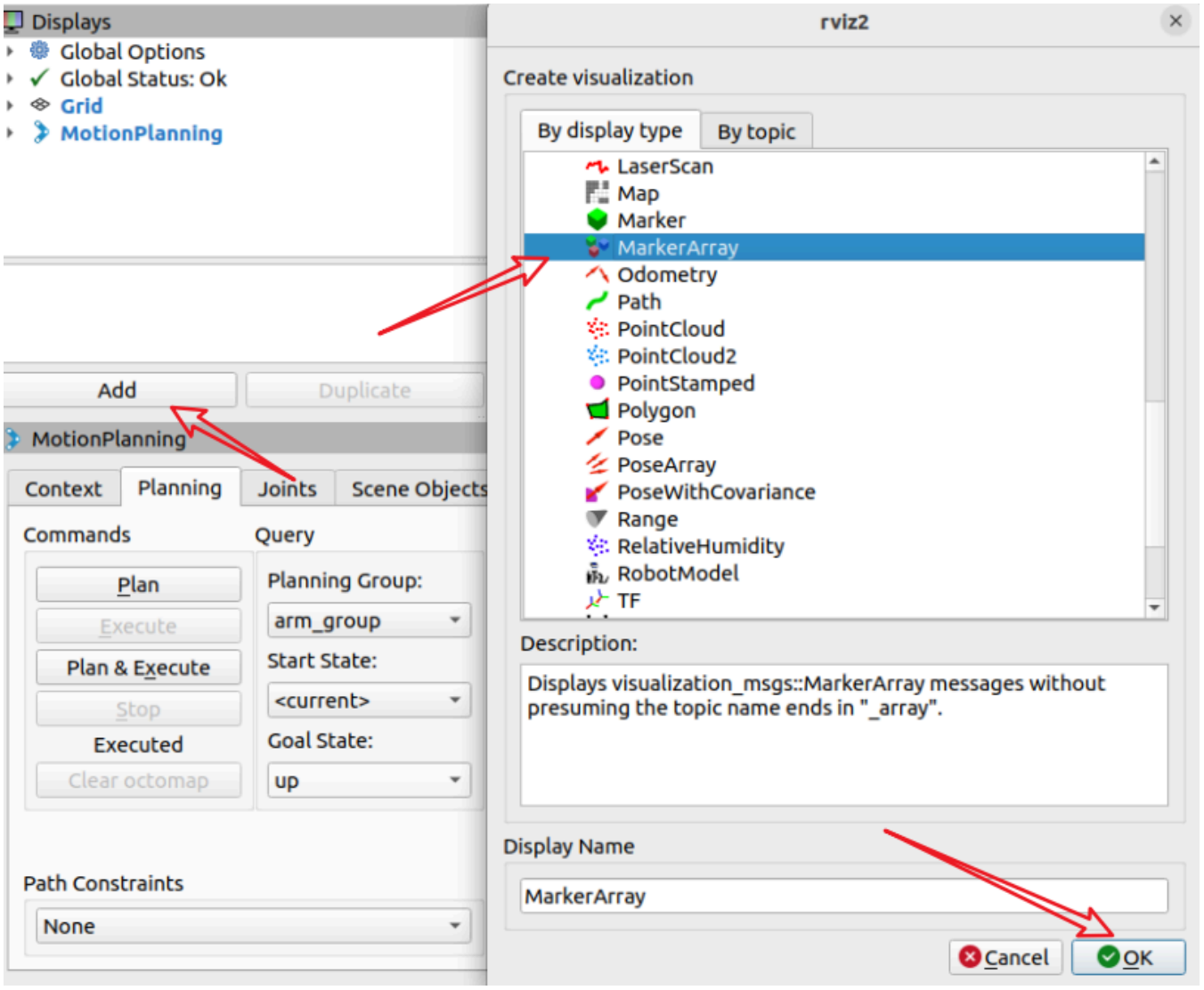
```
ros2 run moveit_demo SimulationToMachine
```

(It is recommended not to start this node during the initial test. First verify that the obstacle-avoidance trajectory is correct in the pure RViz simulation environment before connecting to the real machine).

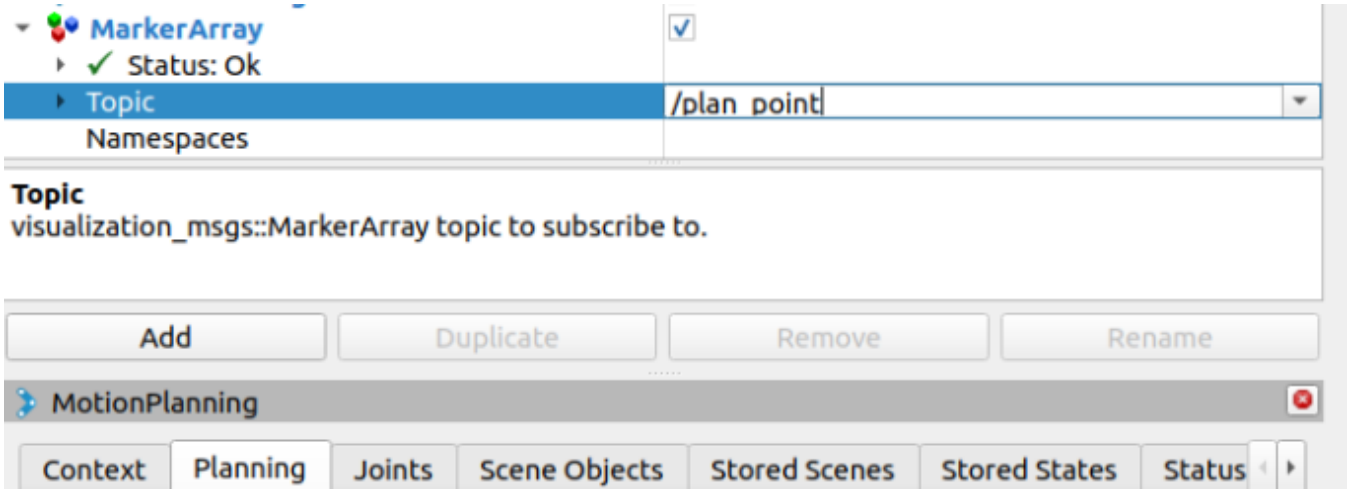
2.3 Configuring the Trajectory Visualization Plugin in RViz

In order to intuitively see the green spatial straight-line trajectory planned for the robot arm's end effector in RViz, we need to add a `MarkerArray` display item:

1. Click the 【Add】 button in the lower left corner of RViz, find and select 【MarkerArray】 in the list, and click 【OK】 to add it, as shown in the figure below:



2. Expand the just-added 【MarkerArray】 in the Displays list, and change the subscribed Topic to `/plan_point`, as shown in the figure below:

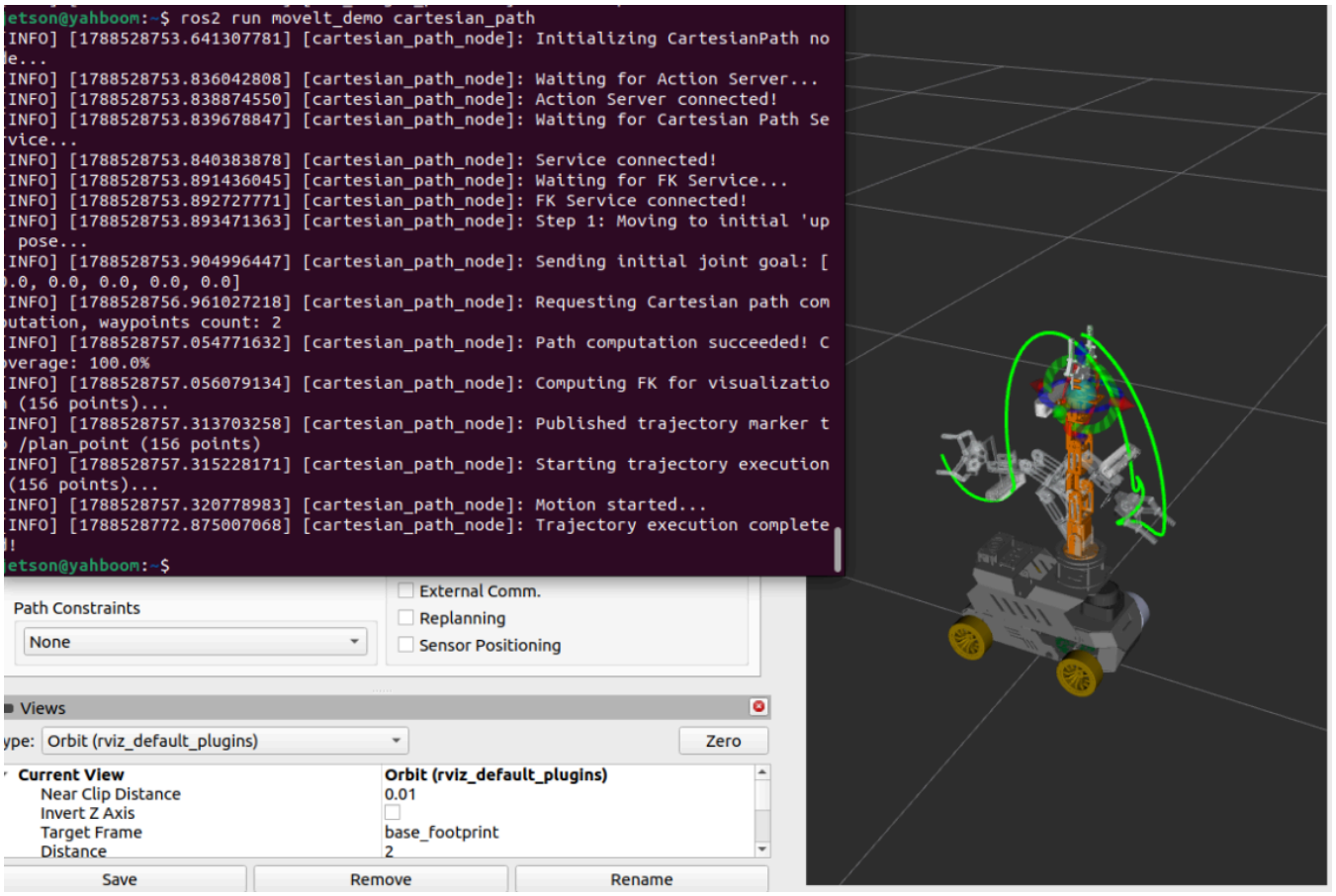


2.4 Running the Cartesian Path Planning Program

Open a new terminal and enter the following command to run the Cartesian path planning script:

```
ros2 run moveIt_demo cartesian_path
```

After running, the robot arm first automatically moves to the initial vertical pose, then starts to compute the Cartesian straight-line trajectory between the two groups of spatial waypoints, and draws a bright green 3D path line (Line Strip) in RViz. The end effector strictly moves smoothly along the straight line, as shown in the figure below:



3. Core Code Analysis

Program source code path:
`~/yahboomcar_ros2_ws/dofbot_pro_ws/src/moveIt_demo/moveIt_demo/cartesian_path.py`

3.1 Node Initialization and Interface Definition

The program is natively developed in ROS 2 Python. The node class `CartesianPath` inherits from `rclpy.node.Node` and defines four core communication clients:

1. `FollowJointTrajectory` **Action client**: Sends trajectories to the `/arm_group_controller/follow_joint_trajectory` action server for execution;
2. `GetCartesianPath` **service client**: Calls MoveIt's `/compute_cartesian_path` service to compute the Cartesian linear trajectory;
3. `GetPositionFK` **service client**: Calls the `/compute_fk` service to perform forward kinematics computation on the trajectory points, inversely deriving the end-effector 3D Cartesian coordinates;
4. `MarkerArray` **publisher**: Publishes visualization line segment messages to the topic `/plan_point` for RViz rendering.

```
import rclpy
```

```
from rclpy.node import Node
from rclpy.action import ActionClient
from control_msgs.action import FollowJointTrajectory
from trajectory_msgs.msg import JointTrajectory, JointTrajectoryPoint
from builtin_interfaces.msg import Duration
from geometry_msgs.msg import Pose, Point
from moveit_msgs.srv import GetCartesianPath, GetPositionFK
from visualization_msgs.msg import Marker, MarkerArray
from std_msgs.msg import ColorRGBA

class CartesianPath(Node):
    def __init__(self):
        super().__init__('cartesian_path_node')
        self.get_logger().info("Initializing CartesianPath node...")

        # 1. Trajectory execution Action client
        self._action_client = ActionClient(
            self,
            FollowJointTrajectory,
            '/arm_group_controller/follow_joint_trajectory'
        )

        # 2. Cartesian path planning service client
        self._cartesian_client = self.create_client(GetCartesianPath,
'/compute_cartesian_path')

        # 3. The 5 robot arm joint names
        self.joint_names = [
            "arm1_Joint", "arm2_Joint", "arm3_Joint",
            "arm4_Joint", "arm5_Joint"
        ]

        # 4. MarkerArray visualization publisher
        self._marker_pub = self.create_publisher(MarkerArray, '/plan_point', 1)

        # 5. Forward kinematics (FK) service client: used to compute the spatial trajectory
point positions
        self._fk_client = self.create_client(GetPositionFK, '/compute_fk')
```

3.2 Cartesian Path Solving Mechanism

In the `compute_cartesian_path` function, we construct a `GetCartesianPath.Request()` request:

- `group_name = "arm_group"`: Specifies the planning group as the 5-DOF arm;
- `link_name = "Gripping"`: Specifies the end-effector constraint tool link as the gripper;
- `waypoints`: Passes in the target waypoint list;
- `max_step = 0.01`: The maximum step size for end-effector interpolation is 1 centimeter (0.01 meters). The smaller the step size, the higher the precision of the straight-line trajectory;
- `jump_threshold = 0.0`: Joint sudden-change jump threshold; setting it to 0.0 disables the sudden-change check.

```
    def compute_cartesian_path(self, waypoints):
        """Call the /compute_cartesian_path service to compute the Cartesian trajectory"""
        request = GetCartesianPath.Request()
        request.header.frame_id = "base_link"
        request.header.stamp = self.get_clock().now().to_msg()

        request.group_name = "arm_group"
        request.link_name = "Gripping"

        request.waypoints = waypoints
        request.max_step = 0.01        # Interpolation micro step size: 1cm
        request.jump_threshold = 0.0   # Disable the jump threshold
        request.avoid_collisions = False

        request.start_state.joint_state.name = self.joint_names
        request.start_state.joint_state.position = [0.0] * 5

        future = self._cartesian_client.call_async(request)
        rclpy.spin_until_future_complete(self, future)

        response = future.result()
        if response.error_code.val == response.error_code.SUCCESS:
            fraction = response.fraction
            self.get_logger().info(f"Cartesian path computed successfully, planning
completion rate: {fraction*100:.1f}%")
            return response.solution
        else:
            self.get_logger().error(f"Cartesian path planning failed, error code:
{response.error_code.val}")
            return None
```

> **Note**: `response.fraction` represents the proportion of the path successfully solved by the planning algorithm (0.0 ~ 1.0). When the completion rate is 1.0 (100%), it indicates that the entire straight line lies within the reachable workspace of the robot arm, with no singularities or joint limit constraints encountered.

3.3 Trajectory Forward Kinematics (FK) and Green Line Visualization in RViz

The computed `response.solution` is a series of trajectory points containing the rotation angles of each joint. In order to present the spatial trajectory actually traversed by the end effector as a line in RViz, the program performs forward kinematics on each trajectory point through the `/compute_fk` service to obtain the spatial coordinates (x, y, z) of the end effector `Gripping`, and organizes them into a `Marker.LINE_STRIP`:

```
    def publish_trajectory_line(self, trajectory):
        """Compute the end-effector 3D point set through forward kinematics (FK) and publish
a MarkerArray green line"""
        joint_traj = trajectory.joint_trajectory
        cartesian_points = []

        for pt in joint_traj.points:
            fk_request = GetPositionFK.Request()
            fk_request.header.frame_id = "base_link"
```

```
            fk_request.fk_link_names = ["Gripping"]
            fk_request.robot_state.joint_state.name = joint_traj.joint_names
            fk_request.robot_state.joint_state.position = list(pt.positions)

            future = self._fk_client.call_async(fk_request)
            rclpy.spin_until_future_complete(self, future)
            response = future.result()

            if response.error_code.val == response.error_code.SUCCESS:
                pos = response.pose_stamped[0].pose.position
                cartesian_points.append(Point(x=pos.x, y=pos.y, z=pos.z))

        # Build the MarkerArray
        marker_array = MarkerArray()
        marker = Marker()
        marker.header.frame_id = "base_link"
        marker.type = Marker.LINE_STRIP
        marker.action = Marker.ADD
        marker.scale.x = 0.005  # Line thickness 5mm
        marker.color = ColorRGBA(r=0.0, g=1.0, b=0.0, a=1.0)  # Pure green
        marker.points = cartesian_points
        marker.lifetime = Duration(sec=30, nanosec=0)
        marker_array.markers.append(marker)

        self._marker_pub.publish(marker_array)
```

3.4 Full Task Flow Execution (run Method)

In the main flow, first return to the initial pose, then define two point poses (keeping the orientation unchanged, only modifying the spatial x, y, z coordinates), solve and execute:

```
    def run(self):
        # 1. Move to the initial homing pose
        self.move_to_joints([0.0]*5, move_time=3.0)

        # 2. Define the Cartesian waypoints
        waypoints = []
        safe_orientation = {'x': 0.0, 'y': -0.70711, 'z': 0.0, 'w': 0.70711}

        # Waypoint 1
        p1 = Pose()
        p1.position.x, p1.position.y, p1.position.z = 0.111475, -0.003986, 0.381269
        p1.orientation.x, p1.orientation.y, p1.orientation.z, p1.orientation.w = 0.0,
-0.70711, 0.0, 0.70711
        waypoints.append(p1)

        # Waypoint 2
        p2 = Pose()
        p2.position.x, p2.position.y, p2.position.z = -0.10527, 0.002169, 0.385409
        p2.orientation.x, p2.orientation.y, p2.orientation.z, p2.orientation.w = 0.0,
-0.70711, 0.0, 0.70711
        waypoints.append(p2)
```

```
        # 3. Solve the Cartesian path
        trajectory = self.compute_cartesian_path(waypoints)

        # 4. Visualize and send for execution
        if trajectory:
            self.publish_trajectory_line(trajectory)
            self.execute_trajectory(trajectory)
```